

Exercise 5: Research strategies: *Researching virtual teamworking*

Review:

The advantages of semi-structured interviews with 12 people are that:

You can get rich data on perceptions and experiences of how the company handled virtual team working

You can probe interviewees' answers to get details of their experiences, and you may find something original or unexpected

However:

This is quite small number of people and you will not be able to claim that the information you gather is representative of the perceptions and experiences of people across the whole bank. (Sometimes novice researchers try to achieve representativeness with even small numbers of respondents by trying to recruit people from different parts of an organisation. In fact, you would probably be better off deliberately focusing on practice in just one area – one function of the bank and/or one level of team – and doing a more thorough job of analysing what took place there.)

The advantages of using questionnaires with a much larger number of people are that:

You can get information from many more people, so the responses may be representative of the experiences of all the company employees who worked in virtual teams – or at least *more* representative than the information from a smaller sample.

There is a literature on virtual team working, and you can draw on that to construct your questionnaire. (Where there is not a literature on a topic that you can use in this way, it makes more sense to use a more open approach such as semi-structured interviews.)

However:

With a questionnaire, you create the categories of information that respondents can provide, and so it is likely to be much more of a closed process than an interview. With an interview you can ask an open question such as: 'What were the advantages for you of working in a virtual team?' and use follow-up questions to probe the respondents' answers. With a questionnaire you would typically offer a list of potential advantages and ask respondents to give each of them a rating to indicate how positive they felt about them. You can offer respondents the opportunity to volunteer a category you did not provide (with an 'Other – please give details' box), but you may still miss something.

With a questionnaire, there is no opportunity for you to probe any answers from respondents, or for them to ask you to clarify what you mean by a question.

Each of these two methods requires knowledge and skills on the part of the researcher. In this example, where either approach could be taken, because each has its strengths and limitations, if you have more experience and skill in one method rather than the other, this may quite naturally influence your choice of which to use.

You may be tempted to decide to use both methods as a way of getting the best of each and minimising their limitations. But beware: this involves you doing twice as much design work, justification, explanation and analysis as using only one method.

Note that the final draft research objective: *Recommend actions to be taken in the future for any continuation of virtual teamworking in Big Bank company* may be taken to indicate that some research is needed into the experiences of a fairly large number of Big Bank employees, and so may incline you towards a questionnaire. However, if you were to carry out qualitative research with a small number of respondents for your MBA dissertation, your recommendation could be about further research that should be carried out to discover how representative your findings were.